



Marine iguana

Amblyrhynchus cristatus

The remote Galapagos Islands, straddling the Equator in the Pacific Ocean, are famed for their unique animals. The islands' marine iguanas are especially interesting, being the only marine lizard that feeds exclusively on seaweed.

Agile in water

Marine iguanas do not live in the sea but gather in colonies on rocky shorelines. They spend the early hours of daylight basking in the sun so that their bodies are warmed enough for a busy day of swimming and feeding. When ready, the lizards plunge into the deep water, diving to depths of 33 ft (10 m) to graze on the short seaweeds that grow on the sunlit rocks of the seabed. An iguana can stay under for an hour if it has to, but most feeding dives last a few minutes before the animal surfaces to breathe. With its plump body and short legs, the marine iguana is ungainly on land but very agile in the water. It has partially webbed feet, but swims mainly with the help of its flattened, oar-shaped tail, while the crest of spines along its back provides stability.

Warm on land

A marine iguana cannot remain in the sea for long. The chilly water begins to make it lethargic, and so it must get out of the water regularly to warm up in the sunshine. After eating it climbs back up the slippery rocks, gripping on with long, hooked claws. Its dark leathery skin helps it to absorb heat more quickly.

As it dries out, the body color becomes a paler gray, with blotches of orange, green, and other colors appearing. These are most pronounced in adult males, which develop vibrant coloring to attract mates. The colors are derived from the pigments in the seaweed they eat and, therefore, vary from island to island. The faces of male and female marine iguanas are also streaked with white. This is the excess salt consumed in their food, which is excreted through glands in the nose.

Along with boosting body temperature, the time spent on land is an opportunity for the iguanas to digest the tough seaweed. This is done with the aid of gut bacteria inside a bulbous fermentation chamber, hence the iguana's large and rotund figure.

Big not always best

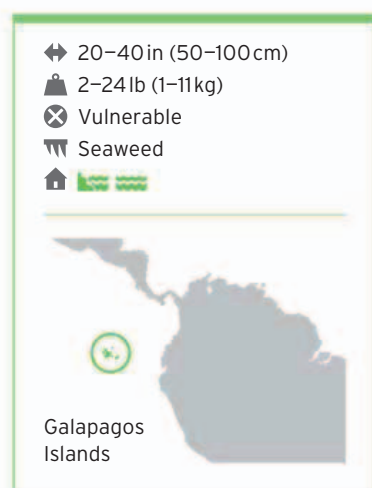
Males can grow to twice the size of females, and they will guard a harem of mates from rivals during the breeding season. Conflicts are generally a show of bluff and bluster, with a dominant male bobbing his head at a rival, who normally withdraws. If he bobs back, however, the rivals will fight, each trying to shove the other away with his head. Large size helps with this, but is a hindrance in other ways. Bigger lizards take longer to warm up between foraging dives, and when seaweed cover in the water is low due to climatic events—such as El Niño—they cannot feed as often as their smaller counterparts.

△ MARINE IGUANA COLONY

Iguanas bask in the sunshine in colonies, their dark bodies helping them to both absorb the sun's warmth and blend in among the volcanic rocks and sand.

◁ UNDERWATER MEAL

The marine iguana gets all of its food from the seabed. It uses its hard, horny lips to scrape away the sea lettuce that grows on rocks.



When **food is scarce**, the marine iguana can **reduce its body size**, including **shrinking its skeleton** by 10 percent